

How to become a great Product Manager, according to 16 of them



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Hey! 🙋 I'm Clo and I'd like to share with you what I learnt about Product Management from interviewing PMs operating all around the planet.



The discussions happened online, but this is what it would have looked like in real life 📝☕ — Thank you Alejandro Escamilla (on Unsplash) for embodying my thoughts so precisely!

I was quite curious and enthusiastic about this position, so I started contacting Product Managers out of the blue. My main enquiries were about: 1) how to obtain my first PM job, and 2) how to actually be good at it.

I exchanged with 16 people (10 men, 6 women) with up to 20 years of experience. I've reached them through LinkedIn (44%), Twitter (31%) and Slack (25%). 🌍 They come from Amsterdam, Detroit (MI), Dublin, London, NYC, Oakland (CA), Paris, San Francisco (CA), Seattle (WA), Sydney, and Toronto.

I'd like to stress that at first, I wasn't planning on writing an article out of those conversations. Then I realised I was gathering a lot of information... and I thought it might as well be useful to more aspiring Product Managers. Sharing is caring, right? 😊

My entire content comes from the great people I could interview, as I am not myself qualified on this subject. I assembled the material into lists of topics that fitted together. Please forgive my drafted lists of bits, as I didn't know I would be writing an article during most of the discussions.

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Here are the references and pieces of advice I've been given.

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Getting your very first Product Manager job

Your first steps

As we know, it can be tricky to enter the field of Product Management without experience in it. Keep in mind that 'difficult' doesn't mean 'impossible'. Product Managers I've talked to come from different fields: engineering, marketing, project management, consulting, finance, UX design, socio-economics, etc. This is a rather wide range of activities, and yes, some have more in common with Product than others. Just remember that today, almost no one actually *stems from* Product.

The one thing that's absolutely required is experience with user persona. Challenge and widen your sense of empathy as soon as you can. It is the keystone of your ability to blossom and improve as a PM.

Have an updated website to showcase your work, your successes, your personality.

Network and make the most of the Product community. Attend meetups, read a lot, be active in Slack groups (see Slack suggestions below). Approach people by outlining your project, find a way to pick their brain. Engage in business discussions, find trends and think about 'why'. As an interviewee put it:

Your career is a lot about manufactured serendipity.

Find a mentor. Find. a. mentor. An experienced PM. Reach out to people who impress, even scare you. Ask about what they read, what surprised them recently.

Certifications

If you don't have prior experience in agile environments, a certification can

help but isn't *necessary*.

Scrum Alliance has a Product Owner course.

Pluralsight has a vast choice of programs.

Where to start your PM career

The best is to begin in a startup where either you're the only PM, or you have a senior PM to guide you. If you're the only one, you will simply learn a lot by doing a lot.

However, big companies are generally more willing to hire junior PMs than startups. Just be aware that you may not have as much freedom and autonomy at heavily hierarchical firms.

Not to promote my city over other ones, but interviewees said startups in Paris were quite hungry for Product Managers 😊

Convert the try

Lots of my interviewees naturally started transitioning to a PM role because they were interested in it and there was a need for it at their current organisation. That's more likely to happen in startups, where there could just be an emptiness to fill. In that case, it will be crucial to educate your coworkers about the edge Product Management provides to the team. If your firm already involves PMs, you can offer to help them by owning some features.

Create your own product and explore. That can happen either in a startup you create (entrepreneurship) or in your present firm (intrapreneurship). Feel free to experiment with hackathons and side projects, as great ideas may come out of it.

If you have financial stability, you can go to people and offer to work for them for free, just to get experience. Another option is to look out for

internships or junior job offers.

The main move is finding a company you are passionate about. Then, you can learn, thrive and get noticed there, even if that involves going sideways or down in the organisation before you go back up.

Grow progressively. Specialise in one field (eg: e-business) and learn more skills from there.

Don't be intimidated by job offers not having the 'junior' mention. If recruiters ask for 3 years or less, don't restrain from applying. Your motivation, everything you already know and have already done still matter a lot.

Show you are able of creatively solving challenges. Work with early prototypes, look for validation: do the work that you will be asked for in interviews.

Make the most of LinkedIn and Indeed alerts, with job offers delivered straight to your inbox.

Practice ahead with The PM Interview and usual questions. *How would you test x or y feature?* The more you go to interviews, the more self-assured you will feel.

Find someone you can convince to take a chance on you.

During the interview

You should show how passionate you are about Product Management. Be open about what inspires you in this field, and be honest about what you are yet to learn.

It's important to clarify why you want to be a PM and why you would be a good one. Highlight your soft skills, as they matter a lot for this position. Mention your beliefs regarding good practices. It will allow the interviewer

to understand how much you know about this role and how you identify with it.

Try to be experienced on as many topics as possible (programming, business strategy, UX design, project management, data science, etc.). MOOCs are a nice way to gather skills on the side.

Don't be afraid to take credit for your work, don't undermine your previous achievements. We usually talk about the team as 'we', but you should also be able to say 'I' regarding previous work accomplishments.

Display important metrics to the interviewers. Did you lead an under-budgeted project? Did you complete a project ahead of time? Present what you drove and changed. Explain how you made decisions. If a previous project went bad, analyse why and describe what you learnt from it.

Show you're inspired by the frameworks/processes of the company, indicate what you've understood of it.

Having worked with PMs before is a good help, provided you can demonstrate what you got out of it.

Remember to position your experience and skills accordingly to what is required for the job.

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How to actually be a good Product Manager

The job

Product Management starts at the earliest stage of the product lifecycle. Define what you aim to go after, identify the market to target, and then understand it. Creating the roadmap, defining the user stories and prioritising the product backlog will require you to be at the intersection of

all disciplines. Thus it's more interesting to be curious and rather good in various areas, rather than brilliant at one single thing.

Focus on the issues customers are trying to solve, rather than jumping right into solution mode. Even in later stages of your work, be sure to stay in love with the problem instead of the solution you're building.

Where to go next can be tough to arbitrate. You need to have enough feel to take action between exploring more and building.

The PM endorses ideas and decisions, argues, and makes sure nothing gets lost. You should be pushy, responsible, and ready to stand firmly for what you believe in. You should also be able to admit mistakes or ignorance.

You shall craft the 'why'. Provide good vision and communicate advancement to stakeholders, both in and out of the team. Think of them as users, understand their drives. Make sure everybody is aligned with the same goal, and do so as early as possible. If you aim for absolute transparency, let them peek into the roadmap! To quote an interviewee:

Good Product Managers are able to get people not on their teams to work for them.

Be the ultimate enabler for your teammates. Being able to translate broad concepts and narrow them down into features and tactics will be a great way to support your team. Instill the faith they'll have in you, lead them and oil the wheels for them. Take advantage of agile's retros to discuss issues anyone may encounter. Here's another sentence I really enjoyed:

A good Product Manager keeps their calm and vision even if the product is on fire.

Users

You need to know who you're making the product for. Pro tip: focus on your users rather than your boss. You are their *representative* in the company. Find their issue and bring them the right solution.

In order to do so, you will go through a Discovery phase:

- 1) Know your target
- 2) Know their jobs
- 3) Know their issues/troubles

You should have user journeys in mind at all time.

Data

Product Managers use qualitative data (interviews) as well as quantitative data (metrics) to guide their decisions. You will need both to be successful because quantitative data will tell you 'what', whereas qualitative data will answer to 'why'.

Be aware that company founders sometimes grant too much importance to their gut-feelings and not enough to measurable insight.

Working on an existing product

Figure out its weak spots, and then bridge the gap between that and what will solve the users' issues.

Working on a new product

One of the 1st things to focus on is reaching your target. This will allow you to have a user base as large as possible, and thus gain relevant, qualified feedback. This is particularly difficult because for people to test your product, you have to change their habits into making them give it a try.

Start small to be able to make fast decisions, as your MVP will change a lot in the early stages.

The various ways of being a PM

Being a PM can mean very different things depending on which company you work at, and which product you work on. Since a job title is very vague, be sure to check the details of the offer.

For instance, the US vision of a PM is to be the real *owner*, responsible for a product. He/she is the key to a collaborative team, in the middle of all stakeholders (business, tech, board, external partners, etc.). However, not all companies operate this way.

Another big difference lies in B2B versus B2C products. In B2C, decision-making will mostly be data-driven, whereas B2B is more likely to follow a case-by-case approach. Being available for your customers is always valuable, but it's even more decisive in B2B systems.

Generally speaking, don't hesitate to ask as many questions as needed regarding the position and what will be incumbent upon you. It's better to be confident that you will enjoy the job and the company culture than to go on board without any sign of it.

General advice for beginners

In order to learn and grow as a Product Manager, do as much as possible yourself.

Be aware that you're not the CEO of the product.

Don't underestimate the weight of informal chat and spontaneous meetings. An unprompted talk starting at the coffee machine can lead anywhere!

Perpetual improvement throughout your career

Be patient with yourself.

Make good use of your time.

Form good habits.

Always be eager and willing to learn.

Ask for feedback from all types of coworkers you interact with —
irrespective of their job and hierarchical status.

Sharing know-how works both ways. You can gain knowledge from more senior Product Managers, or collaborators from different fields/companies/industries. They are often eager to relate their struggles and tips, provided you show interest in it. However, don't forget that you should also pass it on to people with less experience — and they are likely to teach you a thing or two as well!

Read a lot — including books — and take notes. Part of your job is actually to learn new frameworks, methods, and processes, so don't be afraid to read at work.

To paraphrase a respondent:

If you feel safe and pampered, then you haven't
challenged yourself enough.

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Working as a remote Product Manager

Advantages of remote teams

Freedom

Flexibility

More efficient work because less time is spent on chitchat

Tips for sustainable teamwork

Use written communication a lot.

Don't be afraid to repeat yourself. Minimise back-and-forth exchanges.

Avoid sarcasm and ambiguity.

Stay positive and authentic.

Make sure everyone feels included.

Organise retreats to allow the team to have fun together.

Take advantage of remote collaboration tools.

Two related key points for remote teams

Trust is the key to perform efficiently, spread vision about the product, and avoid resentment and questioning about productivity. You will gain it by demonstrating leadership and competency.

Transparency is also very important in setting goals and prioritising. It will allow making sure that everyone feels part of the team beyond their individual work.

Hubs

Some remote companies settle in hub cities for employees who still want to experience the office life, whether it is permanently or temporarily.

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Where to learn from

Meetups, Slack groups, companies and communities to follow

- Intercom
- LPCx [🇫🇷]
- Mind the Product — special mention for the #jobs, #pmmentoring and #women-in-product Slack channels
- Product School
- Product Tank — which came out of Mind the Product
- Startup Weekend
- Thiga
- Women in Product — special mention for the #gendered, #job-opportunities and #mentoring Slack channels
- Women in Product Paris — a friendly and welcoming space, come join us! 🌈
- Xpedition [🇫🇷]

Frameworks

- Scrum
- Kanban
- Scrumban
- Design Thinking and Design sprints
- Jobs To Be Done — focuses on the problems users face rather than the solutions they claim they need.

Tools

- Discourse
- Hangouts

- Intercom
- Nuclino
- Slack
- Zoom

People

- Janna Bastow — CEO and co-founder of ProdPad, co-founder of Mind The Product and Product Tank
- Ken Norton — Partner at GV, former Product Manager at Google and Yahoo
- Chris Spiek — pioneered Jobs To Be Done, half of Demand Thinking
- Des Traynor — co-founder of Intercom
- Tony Ulwick — pioneered Jobs To Be Done, founder of Strategyn

Resources

Articles

- Product Managers — You Are Not the CEO of Anything by Martin Eriksson
- Good Product Manager/Bad Product Manager by Ben Horowitz
- Product Managing your job hunt by Raphaël Korach
- My advice to aspiring Product Managers by Tom Redman
- What makes a great Product Manager by Lawrence Ripsher
- 2017 Product Management and Marketing survey by Pragmatic Marketing
- Quora on Product Management can be interesting as well

Books

- *Inspired: How To Create Products Customers Love* by Marty Cagan
- *Competing Against Luck: The Story of Innovation and Customer Choice* by Clayton Christensen
- *Hooked: How to build Habit-Forming Products* by Nir Eyal
- *Cracking the PM Interview: How to Land a Product Manager Job in Technology* by Gayle Laakmann McDowell and Jackie Bavaro
- *Product Management for Dummies* by Brian Lawley and Pamela Schure
- *Running Lean: Iterate from Plan A to a Plan That Works* by Ash Maurya
- *The Lean Startup: How Today's Entrepreneurs Use Continuous Innovation to Create Radically Successful Businesses* by Eric Ries
- *Customer Success: How Innovative Companies Are Reducing Churn and Growing Recurring Revenue* by Dan Steinman, Nick Mehta and Lincoln Murphy
- *A guide to agile Product Management* by Thiga

Podcasts

- This is Product Management
- Demand Thinking — unfortunately, there's only 2 episodes

Training / Bootcamps

- Product School
- General Assembly
- Lynda.com

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You can now take it to the next level!

Congrats on making it to the end!

I hope this article was as insightful to read as it was for me to put together.

I'd love to answer any questions or remarks you may have.

Diversity — of all sorts — in Tech and Product still has room for improvement. Let's hope for a more inclusive field in the years to come 💖

A big **THANK YOU** goes to all the Product Managers who were kind enough to spend time with a curious stranger full of questions. I'm extremely grateful for their trust.

You can find me on Twitter if you'd like to chat 😊

Product Management Job Interview Remote Work Self Improvement